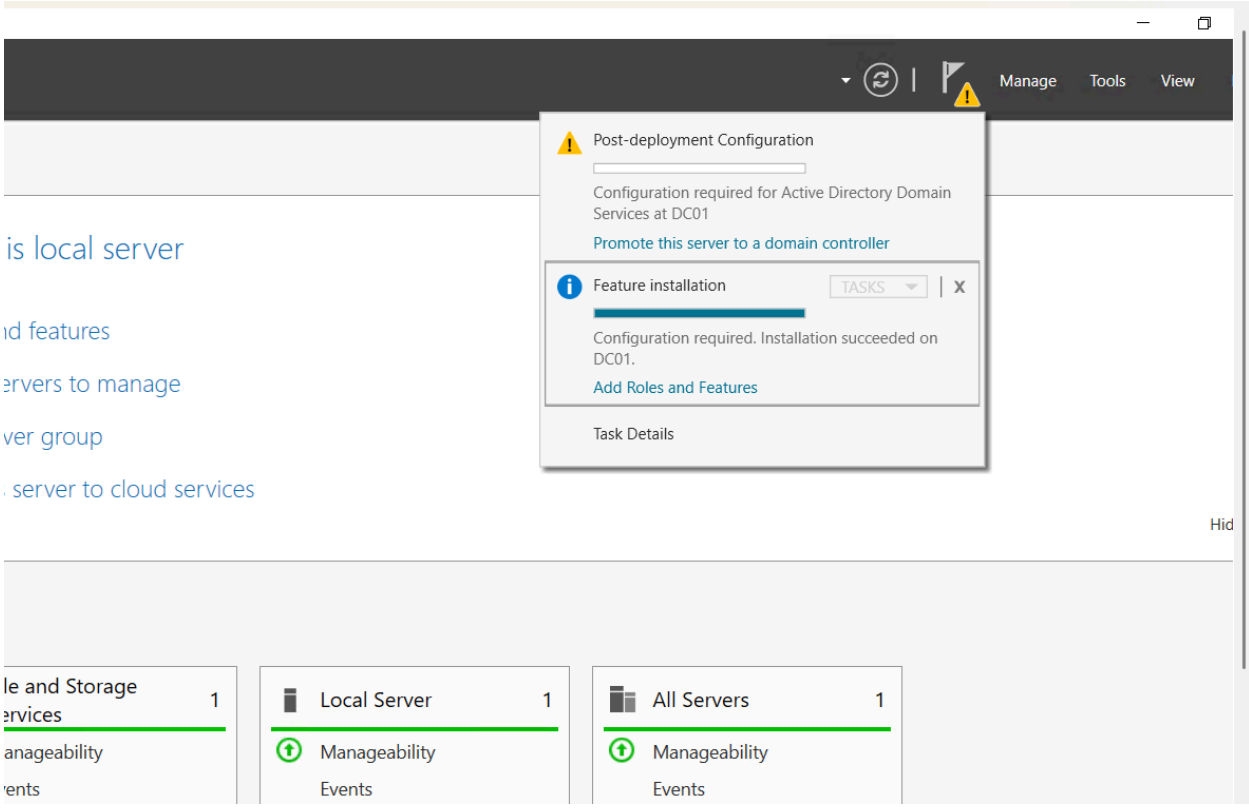
Step 3 — Promote the Server to a Domain Controller

In this step, I will promote the server to a domain controller and create my first Active Directory domain.
This is the point where Active Directory actually becomes active.

1. Start the Promotion Wizard

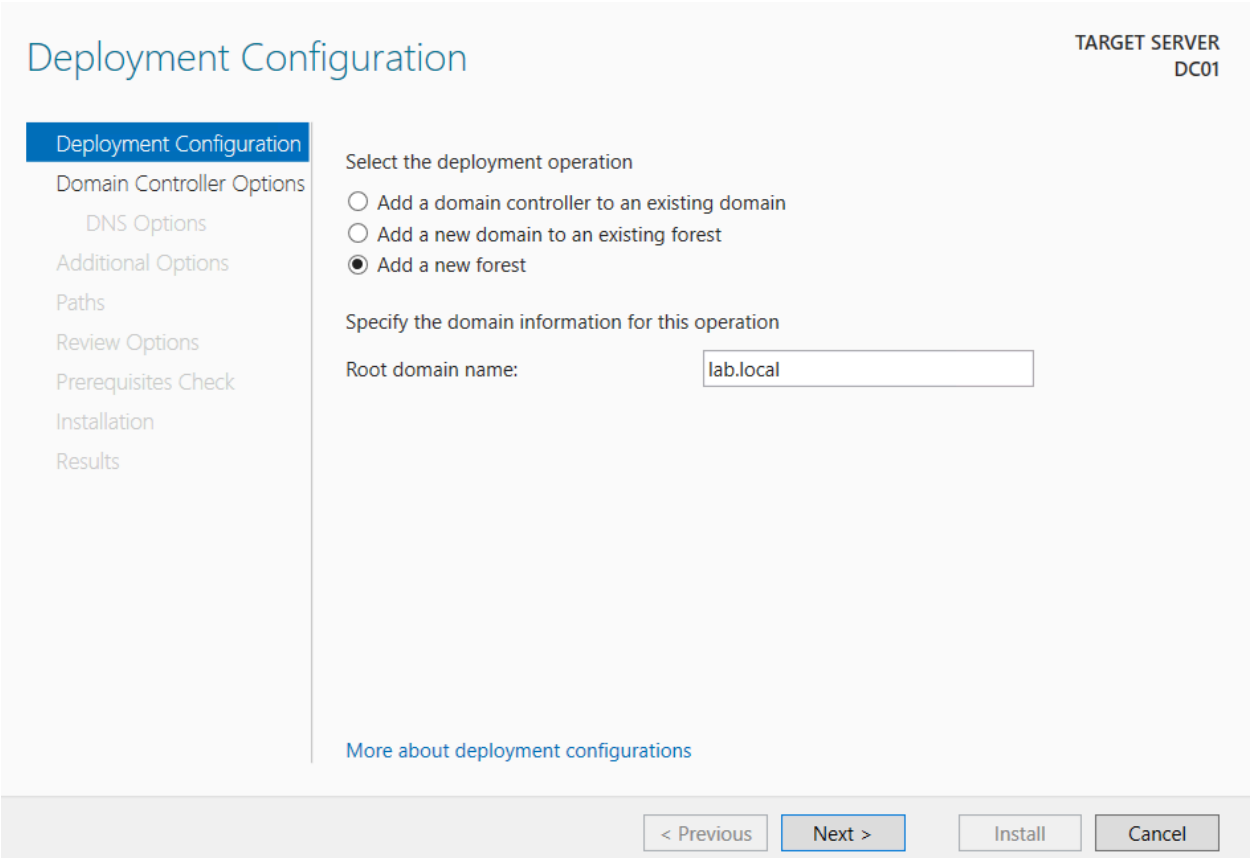
- Open Server Manager
- Select the notification flag at the top of the window
- Click Promote this server to a domain controller



2. Deployment Configuration

You are creating a brand-new Active Directory environment.

- Select Add a new forest



- Root domain name: Choose a private internal domain

Example: `lab.local`

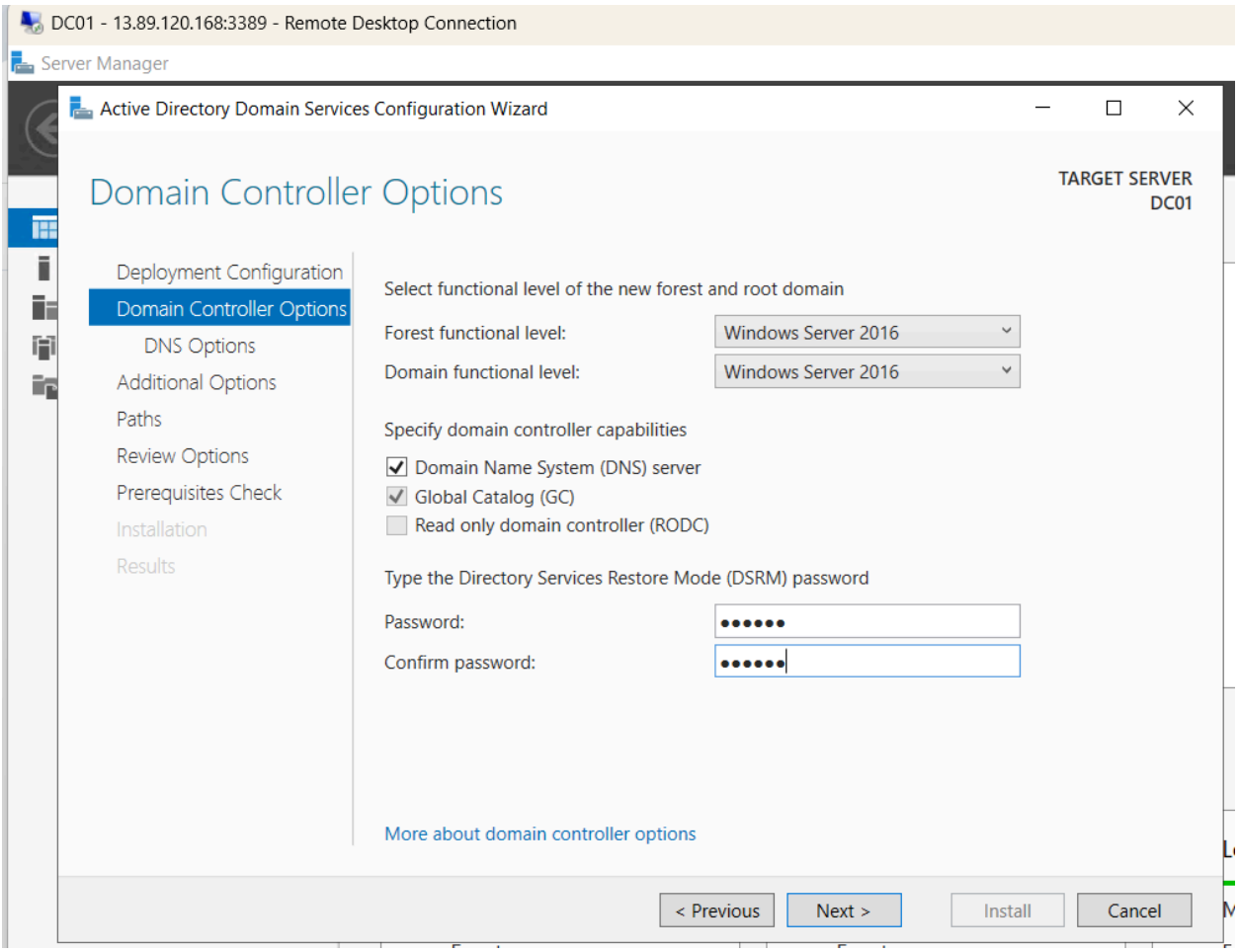
This lab uses a private internal domain. In real environments, domain naming requires more planning.

3. Domain Controller Options

- Forest functional level: Leave default
- Domain functional level: Leave default
- DNS server: Checked (default)
- Global Catalog (GC): Checked (default)

Directory Services Restore Mode (DSRM)

Set a DSRM password and save it. This password is required for recovery scenarios when Active Directory cannot start normally.

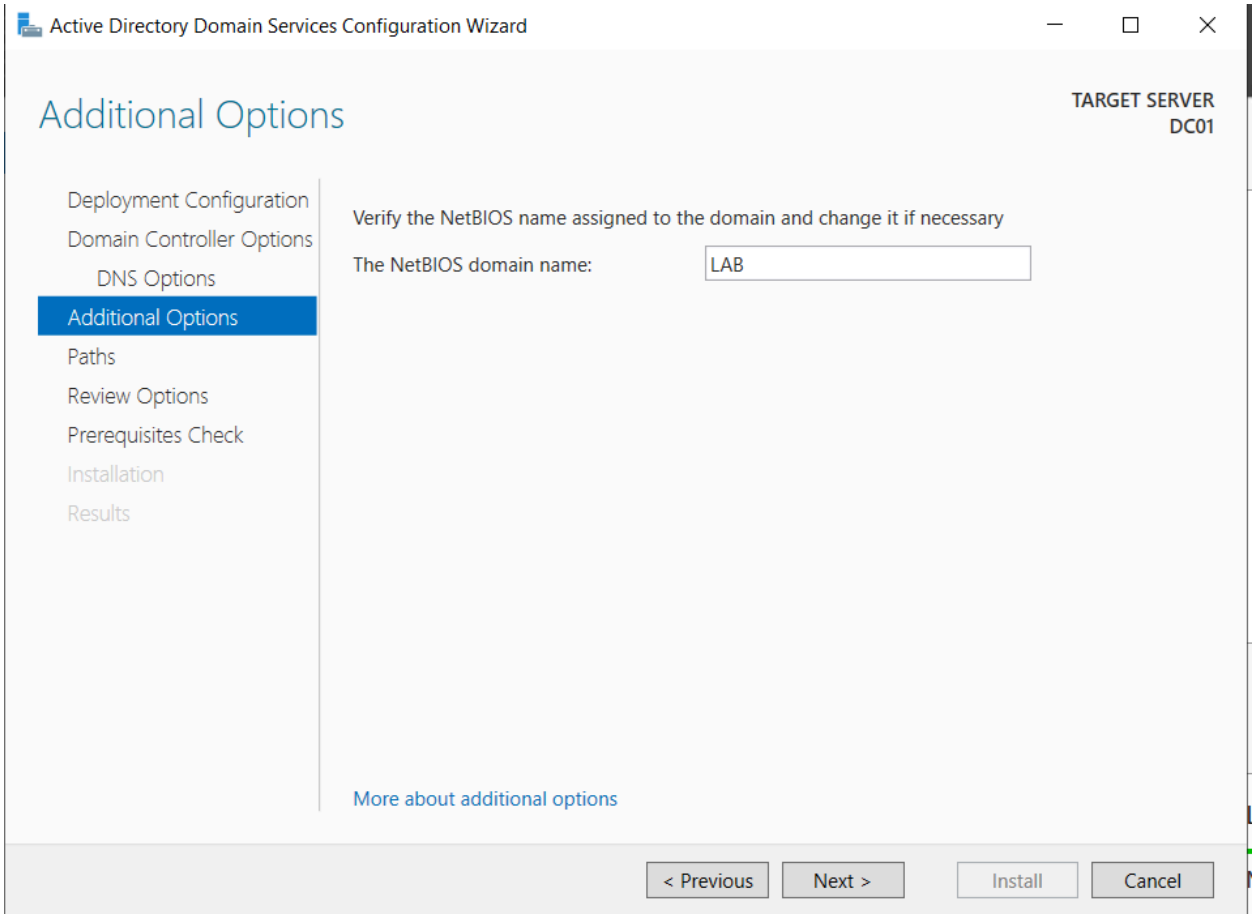


4. DNS Options

- We might see a warning about DNS delegation
- This is expected in a lab environment
- Select Next

5. Additional Options

- NetBIOS domain name: Accept the default



6. Paths

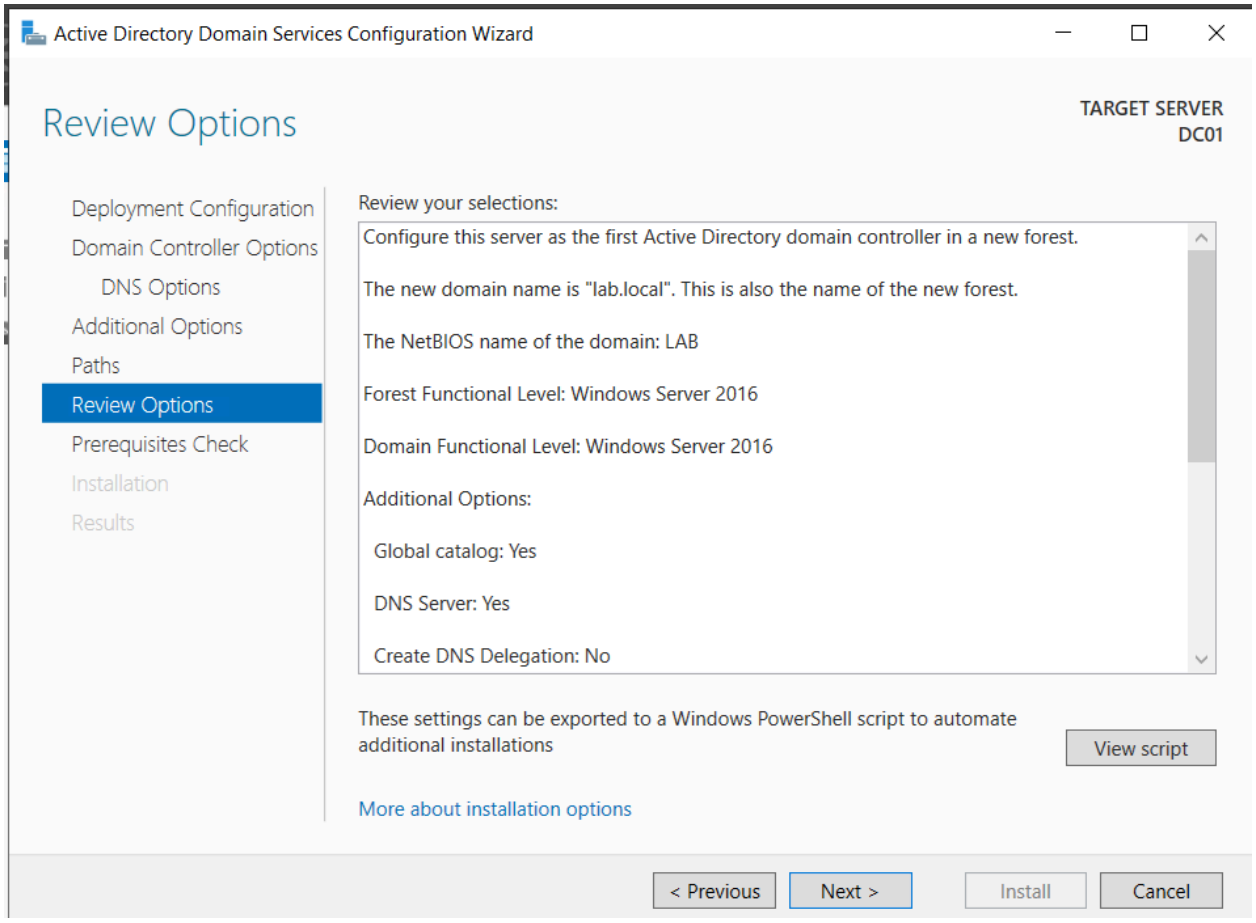
- Leave database, log files, and SYSVOL paths at their defaults

7. Review Options

- Review the configuration summary
- Select Next

8. Prerequisites Check

- Allow all prerequisite checks to complete
- Warnings are acceptable in a lab
- Select Install



9. Reboot and Log In

The server will automatically reboot after promotion completes.
After reboot, log in using your domain administrator account